exploring how things stood in the USSR. He also took aim at liberal artists and creatives, worsening a simmering spat with Ulbricht about youth policy. Upset by a wave of unrest by so-called ‘rowdies’ and ‘beatniks’, Honecker opened a campaign against beat music played on the youth radio station DT64 and the ‘cynical’ compositions of songwriter Wolf Biermann for mocking the ‘old men’ of the SED who, he said, were corrupt and distant, hidden away in Wandlitz. For his efforts, the singer was expelled from the SED and banned from performing. Concern was expressed too at the FDJ for neglecting to teach members in traditional Marxist-Leninist thinking, while Honecker also rallied against hooliganism, long-haired ‘bums’, wayward teenagers and ‘harmful tendencies’ in films, plays, literary works and television programmes.

In the name of ‘abstract truth’ these artists concentrate on the representation of alleged shortcomings and mistakes in the German Democratic Republic. Some writers believe that socialist education can only be successful through the summed-up presentation of shortcomings and mistakes. They do not notice that the effect of their works of art is dragging backwards and inhibiting the development of the socialist consciousness of the working people.

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Reflecting widespread views shared among the old salt, he called for a ‘clean screen’ to protect the viewers from scepticism and immorality. ‘Our GDR is a clean state,’ he explained. ‘In it there are unalterable standards of ethics and morals.’ From here on, before all-important DEFA film projects were approved, Honecker insisted on vetting and approving the script. As West German journalist Dieter Borkowski noted, his ‘artistic judgment was modest’. For example, he raved over a dull biopic of Karl Liebknecht, describing it as ‘exciting as a crime novel!’9 (The narrative of any